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Your PC as a VCR!

Tired of hunting for blank video cassettes every time you want to record your favourite soap while you are away? There's a better way if you look towards the digital realm

The hottest thing about TV today isn't TV anymore. With access to virtually every type of television programme, the challenge is in taking charge of seeing what you want, when you want. Enter Personal Video Recorders (PVRs).

These devices are incredibly utilitarian—just plug your cable TV line into them and you can record straight to the built-in hard disk, then burn all of it onto optical media through a built-in DVD-RW or CD-RW drive. They get even better. You can program them to avoid recording advertisements. They also have timer facilities so that if you don't want to miss *The Simpsons* while working, you can set the clock and the channel and the device does the rest. You can then watch it whenever you want. Besides, having it in a digital format gives you the advantage of enjoying clear digital quality video and sound, and easy distribution through the Internet, P2P networks and other means of sharing.

So where's the catch? Well, the catch is that they cost an arm and a leg. A Toshi-

ba RD X2, with an 80 GB hard disk and DVD burner retails for around \$1,499 (approximately Rs 75,000). The Panasonic DMR-HS2 comes with a 40 GB hard disk and a DVD burner and retails for \$999 (approximately Rs 50,000). Devices like the TiVo let you program the device so that you can see any show by downloading listings from the Internet. Again, they don't come cheap.

But here's the cool thing—you don't have to spend serious money to get most of the features that commercial PVRs give you—a little hardware and software tucked into your PC will give you almost all of this functionality!

Putting together the bits and pieces

You should have the TV tuner card and its driver CD. There may also be additional CDs containing software—it's time to get them all out. You may be prompted for some Windows components, so get hold of your Windows installer CD. Don't forget the screwdriver.

Install the TV Tuner card and drivers: Ground yourself of all static charges by touching a metal object and open the casing of the cabinet. Locate an empty PCI slot in the motherboard and insert the TV Tuner card into it. Apply even pressure along the



The Shopping List

Hardware

- A standard PCI TV Tuner card (available for as little as Rs 2,550 to Rs 3,700). For this workshop we chosen the Pinnacle PCTV Plus (Aditya Infotech Pvt Ltd, Phone: 022-26338555)
- Pentium III 500 MHz processor
- 128 MB RAM
- At least 1 GB of free hard disk space for the replay buffer and additional 1 GB space for saving video footage—the more free space, the better
- A normal coaxial cable that is hooked into your TV to provide cable and satellite TV channels. The RF connector that goes into your card is the same one that goes into the TV set
- If your budget permits it, add a CD-RW drive. You can archive your recorded shows without filling up your hard drive

Software

- PVR software—for this workshop, we are using Cyberlink PowerVCR II 3.0 Deluxe.
- The latest versions of your graphics card drivers and DirectX 8.1 on your system



DirectX 8.1
Cyberlink PowerVCR II
Find them on the
Mindware CD